

» CHEQUERED FLAG FORMULA ONE

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The Singapore Grand Prix is always a heated affair around Marina Bay. The infamous street circuit has produced several thrilling races in recent years, and many expected the 2025 edition to be no different. However, there was more drama within the teams than the action on track.

The 62-lap Singapore GP is one of the toughest races on the calendar. But it ran largely incident-free with no Safety Cars, and all 20 drivers finishing the race for the first time in the event's history.

George Russell built on a stellar qualifying performance to deliver a controlled, error-free race, claiming his second win of the season. The Mercedes driver, often trailing the frontrunners this year, ensured that neither the McLaren drivers nor Max Verstappen could challenge his dominance in the race.

Defending champion Verstappen, yet to conquer the Singaporean challenge, secured second place, fending off a late charge from Lando Norris. The British driver finished ahead of his teammate and rival, Oscar Piastri, a result that cemented McLaren's defence of their constructors' title. For now, the team could celebrate the points haul, but beneath the surface, tensions will be at an all-time high. The papaya pair's brewing rivalry has long been a source of intrigue, but it has increasingly threatened to spill beyond the confines of friendly competition. The latest incident at the race start was a stark reminder.

Piastri and Norris, starting third and fourth respectively, made contact just a few moments in. Norris managed to edge ahead, leaving the Australian visibly frustrated on the radio. It was the opening salvo in an extended period of discontent in his cockpit. The team's decision to review it afterwards only compounded the frustration — "That's not fair. I'm sorry, that's not fair."

After a disappointing weekend in Azerbaijan, Piastri was eager to reclaim lost ground. However, the shaky start and a compromised pit stop significantly dented his chances of extending his lead. McLaren's far-fetched commitment to give both an equal shot has backfired often this season.

For Norris, it was a clear statement of intent that he was ready to take the fight deeper. Last year, he had triumphed at this very circuit, a victory that boosted his confidence and strengthened his belief in pursuing a long-shot title ambition. While Verstappen remained too far ahead for Norris to mount a serious challenge, the situation is more promising now.

A 22-point gap separates the two McLaren drivers. Piastri still holds the lead, but Norris's recent form has kept him well within striking distance. With six races remaining, the numbers suggest that five are still mathematically in contention, yet it is clear the championship is increasingly shaping into a two-way battle — at most three — with all eyes on the McLarens.

Down to the wire

22 points now separate the two McLaren drivers after George Russell **cruised** to a comfortable victory at the Singapore Grand Prix.



Strong hold: Mercedes' George Russell built on a stellar qualifying performance to deliver a controlled, error-free race, claiming his second win of the season. AFP